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Social commerce constructs and consumer's intention to buy

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ABSTRACT

Social commerce is a new development in e-commerce generated by the use of social media to empower customers to interact on the Internet. The recent advancements in ICTs and the emergence of Web 2.0 technologies along with the popularity of social media and social networking sites have seen the development of new social platforms. These platforms facilitate the use of social commerce. Drawing on literature from marketing and information systems (IS) the author proposes a new model to develop our understanding of social commerce using a PLS-SEM methodology to test the model. Results show that Web 2.0 applications are attracting individuals to have interactions as well as generate content on the Internet. Consumers use social commerce constructs for these activities, which in turn increase the level of trust and intention to buy. Implications, limitations, discussion, and future research directions are discussed at the end of the paper.

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1. Introduction

Recent advancements in information and communication technologies (ICTs) and the emergence of Web 2.0 technologies have brought new developments to e-commerce. The popularity of social technologies and platforms such as social networking sites (SNSs) is one of the main reasons for advancement in this area (Liang & Turban, 2011). These developments attract individuals to come online and have interactions with their friends on social platforms such as online communities. The social connections and interactions of people on the internet, especially in social networking sites, the main focus of SNSs (Fue, Li, & Wenyu, 2009), have developed e-commerce to social commerce. These advancements shape a postmodern view of consumers (Füller, Mühlbacher, Matzler, & Jawecki, 2009), where they communicate, rate other products, review others' opinions, participate in forums, share their experiences and recommend products and services. They co-create value with firm (Wang & Hajli, 2014). This is an advantage of social commerce era, where consumers interact and their social interaction influence other consumers (Hajli, Lin, Featherman, & Wang, 2014). Social commerce is mediated by social media (Hajli, 2014a; Jeppesen & Molin, 2003; Shin, 2013) and is mostly related to online communities and SNSs, which have grown rapidly (Lu & Hsiao, 2010). These social platforms give opportunities to consumers to support each other with information exchange and with the content they generate there (Hajli, 2013).

Trust is a challenging issue of e-commerce for consumers (Gefen & Straub, 2000). Trust can now be supported by social commerce as social commerce includes social interactions of consumers, which increase the level of trust (Hajli et al., 2014). Distrust fails to shape a good relationship between consumers and firms (Jones & Leonard, 2008). Therefore, trust is a critical point in an online context. Considering trust as a critical aspect of e-commerce, this research is being directed to investigate the role of social interactions of consumers through social commerce constructs in order to establish trust in e-commerce platforms.

The present study tries to develop social commerce constructs and investigate on the role of these constructs on trust and intention to buy. SCCs are forums and communities, ratings and reviews and referrals and recommendations. Therefore, this study recognizes social commerce constructs and tries to answer these questions: (1) Do social commerce constructs influence consumers' trust and their purchase decisions? (2) Does trust influence social commerce intention?

2. Literature review and theoretical framework

2.1. Social commerce

Social commerce is a new stream and subset of e-commerce (Hajli, 2014b; Kim & Park, 2013), which enables consumers to generate content. Social commerce enables vendors to reach different

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markets by integrating social interactions of consumers (Hargadon & Bechky, 2006). Social commerce is a new development in e-commerce with the popularity of social networking sites and social media that enable consumers to be active content creators on the Internet. A powerful tool for this is social media, which differentiates e-commerce from social commerce. Social commerce is the use of Web 2.0 applications to support interaction of people in an online context where the contribution of users can help in the acquisition of services and products (Liang & Turban, 2011). The popularity of social media sites is the main element for development in this area, introducing new business models as a result (Leitner & Grechenig, 2007; Liang & Turban, 2011). Social media technologies have become social tools and online platforms are now places where users share information and use opinions and experiences of others in music, photographs, insight and knowledge (Lai & Turban, 2008). In this era, SNSs and the attraction of its applications play an important role in the development of social media (Johann, Bartl, Ernst, & Hans, 2006; Liang & Turban, 2011). The mission of SNSs is to create online communities where members can share and seek common interests, activities, experiences and information (Shin, 2010). Social commerce statistics show that this is a promising phenomenon. Social commerce is introducing new business models based on online communities where the objective is to bring features of Web 2.0 technologies to e-commerce in order to design customer-oriented business. The businesses can develop an online community and encourage their consumers to share their knowledge, experiences, and information about their products or services, which forms social commerce strategy for them. Alternatively, the firms may join popular SNSs such as Facebook and sell their product through this channel or ask their consumers to like their page or product to benefit from social commerce. Many companies have their Facebook page and ask their consumers to share their comments about the products or the services on these social platform, which help them to introduce their products or services. Channel, H&M, Selfridge, Dell and many other shops are examples of brands that use social commerce in this context.

2.2. Social commerce constructs

The experience of consumers in an online environment enabled by social media is different to that offline, as the customers have social interactions with other individuals (Do-Hyung, Jumin, & Ingoo, 2007). Today researchers claim that through social media and the emergence of social platforms such as forums and communities, ratings and reviews, and referrals and recommendations, consumers do have sociability. In addition, relationships between e-vendor and consumers are in fact personal. These social platforms are social commerce constructs, which this research will investigate. SCCs are social platforms which have emerged from Web 2.0 and empowered consumers to generate content and share their experiences. They also use others' information, offer advice and share experiences in these platforms providing a source for online social support. Although, SCCs have the same functions to facilitate the sharing of information and establishing social support platforms for consumers, they are different in their technical capabilities.

Ratings and reviews are one of the constructs that shape social commerce. Individuals can easily post their product reviews online (Chen, Xu, & Whinston, 2011) and rate products. These reviews and ratings give comprehensive information about products for the benefit of other potential customers. Research shows that a popular product review by a third party is growing (Yubo & Jinhong, 2005). It is argued that reviews generated by a third party reduce customers' need for advertising information (Yubo & Jinhong, 2005). Therefore, reviews and ratings seem to generate effective information for customers. Additionally, the engagement of consumers in co-creation and content generation empowers them (Füller et al., 2009), where they are able to learn about others' experiences about a product, for instance. Consumers are increasingly co-creating value with firms (Prahalad & Ramaswamy, 2004). Empowerment refers to the capability of social technologies to enable people to have social interaction and collaborate on the Internet (Füller et al., 2009). Research shows that customer feedbacks and ratings promote a higher level of trust (Ba & Pavlou, 2002; Ono et al., 2003). However, information related to the identity of reviewers has an effect on community members' perceptions (Chris, Anindya, & Batia, 2008). This issue has been raised as a result of fake ratings and reviews produced by third parties. E-vendors now have to consider whether to take actions to persuade reviewers to give more information about their identity (Chris et al., 2008) to assure consumers about the authenticity of ratings and reviews.

Recommendations and referrals, the other construct of SCCs, are likely to play an important role on social commerce intention. Research shows, in an online context, as customers cannot experience the products or services, consumers should rely more on other consumers' experiences such as their product recommendations (Senecal & Nantel, 2004). In a high street shop, customers spend their time in store and interact with the staff whereas in an online shop it is a major challenge to create an online store which is socially rich (Kumar, Novak, & Tomkins, 2010).

The third construct of social commerce is forums and communities. Online communities and Internet forums are social environment that facilitate social interaction of individuals. Members of online communities participate in different group activities and support other members through their social interactions and communications in the provided platform (Bagozzi & Dholakia, 2002). They use social technologies, such as social media, online communities and other Web 2.0 applications, to support other members by their experience and information sharing. These communities allow people to obtain information for products and services and to support each other (Y. Lu, Zhao, & Wang, 2010). This type of information, which is created by other consumers, is a new kind of word-of-mouth recommendation as used in traditional markets (Do-Hyung et al., 2007).

2.3. Trust

Trust is a central issue in most economic and social transactions, especially in an online context where there may be lots of uncertainty (Pavlou, 2003). Trust is more important when risks are perceived to be high, as in the case of e-commerce (Mutz, 2005). This area has been widely studied by researchers (Gefen, 2002; Gefen, Karahanna, & Straub, 2003; Kim, 2012; Morid & Shajari, 2012; Mutz, 2005; Pavlou, 2003). It is mostly because trust plays an important role in the e-commerce adoption process (Aljifri, Pons, & Collins, 2003) and it has a significant role in online commerce (Gefen, 2002).

With the increase of social technologies and interconnectivity of people on the Internet, there is a need for some sort of trust and security that will allow two parties to reduce their perceived risk in transactions (Hajli & Lin, 2014). Research shows that people like to reduce their social uncertainty (Gefen & Straub, 2004). It is also argued that if an e-commerce website describes products or services accurately, consumers will trust the website more (Ming-Hsien, Chandlrees, Binshan, & Hung-Yi, 2009). This can be facilitated by social technologies such as customer reviews, information and experiences of others in forums and communities. For instance, when a reputable member of an online forum or community makes a recommendation to a vendor by giving good feedback, the other members are likely to have a high level of trust in the process (Lu et al., 2010).

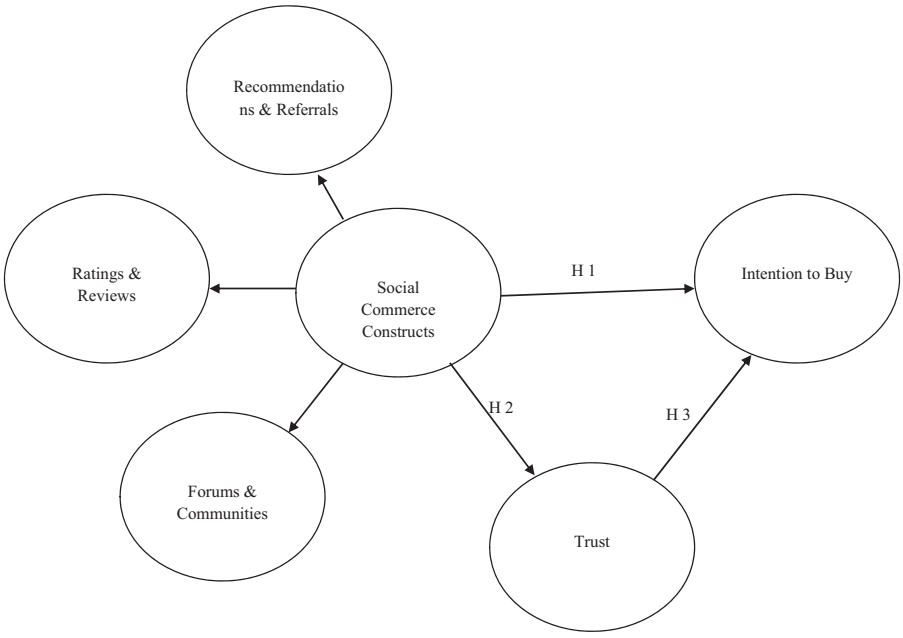


Fig. 1. Social commerce adoption model.

There are differences in the definition of trust, depending on the different dimensions involved. In e-commerce literature, benevolence and credibility are seen as two distinct types of trust (Ba & Pavlou, 2002). Credibility based trust, which usually is impersonal and relies on reputation information, refers to the belief that the other party in a transaction is reliable and honest (Ba & Pavlou, 2002). Benevolence, however, refers to repeated seller-buyer relationships (Ba & Pavlou, 2002). There is also a three dimensional definition of trust (Gefen, 2002) namely integrity, ability and benevolence. Ability refers to the skills of the trusted party, integrity refers to honesty and keeping promises of the e-vendor and finally benevolence is the intention of the trusted party to do well for their consumers (Gefen, 2002; Gefen & Straub, 2004).

In the present environment where social interactions of people on the Internet shape new forms of interconnectivity and relationships between people, the study of trust might be influenced by social relationships of people and the platforms on which they interact. Social trust is important because it reduces "transaction cost" in business interactions (Mutz, 2005). It reduces the tendency to monitor other parties' activities and is an element in sanctioning systems as reliable (Mutz, 2005). In fact, the information from a commercial website is different from information provided by other customers. The information that consumers provide by their reviews is seen to be more trustworthy (Do-Hyung et al., 2007).

To endorse trust in an online environment, it is important to have some mechanisms to provide credible signals to distinguish among sellers (Ba & Pavlou, 2002). For this purpose, SCCs provide recommendations, referrals and ratings. These constructs give sellers reasons to be trustworthy. Social interactions of customers on social platforms and social commerce constructs seem to have an impact on users' behaviour. Researchers agree that social activities in SNSs will increase intention to buy (Han & Windsor, 2011). This research considers two dimensional trusts, benevolence and credibility. Benevolence refers to goodwill trust while credibility covers reliability, integrity and honesty (Pavlou, 2003). The present study defines trust in SNSs as the degree to which the SNS is willing to put into operation its commitment and promises. Therefore, trust is a vital component in the operation of SNSs.

2.4. Intention to buy

Intention to buy is a construct of technology acceptance model (TAM), one of the most successful theories in predicting an individual's intention to use a system (Pavlou, 2003). There are two core theories to test and predict an individual's intention to utilize information systems (Mathieson, 1991). These two theories are TAM and the theory of planned behaviour by Ajzen (1989). Intention to buy in the present study is defined as a customer's intention to engage in online buying in social networking sites. TAM is a core theory in e-commerce studies (Martins, Oliveira, & Popovič, 2014; Park, Roman, Lee, & Chung, 2009) and many authors developed this model (Hsiao & Yang, 2011).

3. Research model and development of hypotheses

In this research a social commerce adoption model has been developed in order to increase our understanding of social commerce and emerging social relationships of individual on the Internet. Specifically, this research investigates the role of SCCs to discover the role of these constructs on a social commerce environment. Along with SCCs, recommendations and referrals, forums and communities and rating and reviews, the researcher added trust and intention to buy as on-going issues in e-commerce. These are included in the model as shown in Fig. 1.

3.1. Social commerce constructs

The emergence of Web 2.0 applications and the ability of users to co-create on the internet has supported consumers in solving tasks while giving them feelings of empowerment and enjoyment (Füller et al., 2009). Research shows that social activities on these platforms have economic implications in the form of product sales (Chris et al., 2008).

The impact of social media in the market can be seen from how e-vendors provide more opportunities than before to interact with consumers (Amblee & Bui, 2011). Social commerce, with the aid of Web 2.0 and social media technology, facilitate consumers' ratings and reviews, and recommendations and referrals. Ratings and

reviews, which enable customers to have a look at friends' reviews, help them in the decision-making process of buying. Brand reputation can also be affected by feedback from reviews (Davidson & Copulsky, 2006). The consumer can turn to online recommendation systems, which seem to have a significant influence on the buyer. However, such systems are often biased according to findings in different markets (Riemer & Lehrke, 2009; Senecal & Nantel, 2004).

Research also shows that reviews by a third party has a significant effect on the purchasing decision of consumers (Yubo & Jinhong, 2005). In fact, one of the main reasons that customer reviews have such influence on sales is related to the value of information and the experience a customer has for a product or service (Chris et al., 2008). This can be shared with consumers who have not had the experience. Research shows that a recommendation as a source of information strongly influences customer behaviour (Senecal & Nantel, 2004). It is also noted that online recommendations strongly influence the online choice of product (Senecal & Nantel, 2004). Participation of people in online communities, with information exchange, is the main reason for joining virtual communities. This has a direct influence on customer behaviour (Ridings & Gefen, 2004). Consequently, this study can hypothesize:

H1. Social commerce constructs have a positive effect on the user's intention to buy.

SCCs also have influence on trust. Research shows customer ratings has influence on the level of trust, which consequently leads to more sales on that platform (Swamynathan, Wilson, Boe, Almeroth, & Zhao, 2008). Ratings will also increase user satisfaction when they undertake a transaction (Swamynathan et al., 2008). In fact, positive ratings have a strong influence on trust formation (Ba & Pavlou, 2002). This research also shows that social context is the other factor that influences trust (Weisberg, Te'eni, & Arman, 2011). When an e-commerce platform has social presence (Weisberg et al., 2011) and social application, consumers feel more secure and consequently they have more intention to buy. Previous research shows that social presence increases the level of trust (Gefen & Straub, 2004) and that social presence can be achieved by SCCs. In fact, social interactions of consumers create social word of mouth which positively affects trust (Kim & Park, 2013). Therefore, the following research hypothesis is hypothesized:

H2. Social commerce constructs have a positive effect on the user's trust.

3.2. Trust

Trust is an important aspect in e-commerce (Gefen & Straub, 2004; Mutz, 2005; Pavlou, 2003) and when rules are not adequate, consumers try to reduce social uncertainty by relying on trust and familiarities (Gefen & Straub, 2004). When people participate in forums and communities or read others' reviews and ratings of a product or service, their level of familiarity to a website or SNSs is likely to increase. This brings trust to the transaction.

Trust has the ability to decrease behavioural hesitation to intend to buy in e-vendor websites (Pavlou, 2003). It gives power of control over the transaction to consumers (Pavlou, 2003). This power helps customers to interact with the website as they deliberate their intention to buy. It is likely that trust in online communities support customers in their shopping behaviour. Research shows that trust positively influences a consumer's intention to buy (Gefen & Straub, 2004; Pavlou, 2003). Trust has the mediating position in an electronic market (Ba & Pavlou, 2002) and in the proposed model has the mediating role. It is mainly due to the fact that trust has a key influence on the success of e-commerce (Ming-Hsien et al., 2009) and it should have the same influence in social commerce.

In addition, it has been confirmed that trust has a significant role in enhancing intention to buy (Lu et al., 2010; Shin, 2010). Having confidence and less perceived risk are important factors when searching for new items or services in an online environment (Hassanein & Head, 2007; Shin, 2010). Hence, it is important to investigate the role of trust on social commerce adoption. In the study of concerns and risks about e-commerce, researchers state that there is a significant relationship between trust and online commerce behaviour (Ba & Pavlou, 2002; Gefen, 2002).

H3. Trust of users in SNSs has a positive effect on intention to buy.

4. Research methodology

An empirical study was conducted to test the relationship between the constructs and a questionnaire was developed for this purpose. The research conducted a survey to collect the data, which is described below.

4.1. Instrument development

The research has four constructs: intention to buy, social commerce constructs, perceived usefulness and trust. To measure the constructs a questionnaire was developed. The research used a five point Likert-scale from 1, strongly disagree to 5, strongly agree. Social commerce constructs include three dimensions: forums and communities, ratings and reviews, referrals and recommendations. The measurements of SCCs are based on participation of individuals in these social platforms. The measurement assessed participation of consumers to generate content, rate, review, recommend and refer products or services. Trust was measured by benevolence and credibility in SNSs. The dependent variable of this research is intention to buy. Intention to buy measures the user's willingness to pay on SNSs and their intention to buy through SNSs.

4.2. Data collection

The data was collected through a survey conducted in the UK in March 2012. We targeted students, mainly in the UK as they are using social networking sites. Before the main survey, a pilot study with 15 students was used to make sure the questions and wordings were clearly understood by respondents. In total 1000 students were identified from various sources for the main survey. The questionnaire was by paper and in an electronic version to maximize the number of participants. The questionnaire, which was sent by email, requested people to participate in the survey. For this research we targeted student union mailing shots and also posted ads in Facebook, asking friends to share the questionnaire. 200 questionnaires were distributed in two universities in London. A total of 280 responses were received. Some of the questionnaires were dropped as they were incomplete. The total valid respondents included 113 males and 130 females. The response range was from 18 to 45 years, with 16% of eighteen to twenty-two years and 84% of twenty-three to forty-five years. The research used a total of 243 usable responses.

4.3. Data analysis and findings

The present study applies Structural Equation Modelling (SEM). SEM as recommended has many advantages over other methods (Gefen, Rigdon, & Straub, 2011; Ringle, Sarstedt, & Straub, 2012). SEM is also good in terms of path and factor analysis, especially when we are looking for reliability and validity of a research outcome from different angles. This is available through this approach. The research chose Partial Least Squares (PLS) method to test the

hypotheses. PLS simultaneously assesses the validity and reliability of constructs (McLure Wasko & Faraj, 2005). PLS has advantages compared to other methods such as LISREL. Sample size is an important issue in SEM and PLS can handle a small sample size (Chin, 1998; Ringle et al., 2012). In addition, PLS is also good for exploratory research (Chin, 1998; Gefen & Straub, 2004), which is the nature of this research. This method is also suitable for testing a new model and theory as it can be good for confirmatory and exploratory research (Gefen et al., 2011).

The research uses the re-sampling method of SmartPLS for significance testing. In the present study the bootstrapping of 200 re-samples and 250 cases per sample was carried out in order to assess the path significance. The estimate of bootstrap provides the basis for confidence intervals allowing an estimation of factor stability (Ringle et al., 2012).

4.4. Measurement model

4.4.1. Reliability

Reliability in a survey is the stability of the measures it uses (Sapsford, 2006). Each survey constructs have different items which assess internal consistency (McLure Wasko & Faraj, 2005; Straub, Boudreau, & Gefen, 2004). There are different methods available to test the internal consistency. In PLS it is advisable to calculate the composite reliability, where the accepted value should exceed 0.70 and should be interpreted by Cronbach's alpha (McLure Wasko & Faraj, 2005). The results of the composite reliability as shown in Table 1 indicate an acceptable rate and show the research has an internal consistency. To measure reliability, the research also tested the internal consistency, which can be calculated by Cronbach's alpha, as seen in Table 1. All constructs have a value more than 0.70, an acceptable value for this test. Moreover, to improve the reliability of the test, the author amended the questionnaire after the pilot study, as the check for reliability of the research depends on piloting of the instrument and question wording (Bell, 2010). These two types of reliability tests ensure we can analyze the data accurately for the survey.

4.4.2. Validity

To have a high content validity, the author undertook a substantial literature review in the area of e-commerce and social commerce and piloted it with 15 students. The face validity was the other object of this test (Gefen, 2002). Each of the students was asked to check if the scale items were appropriate and unambiguous. Moreover, some of the constructs – trust and intention to buy – are taken from existing literature and have been frequently shown to demonstrate evidence of strong content validity (Gefen et al., 2003; Pavlou, 2003). The literature source for each construct, which has been used in the literature review, is indicated in Table 1. Noticeably, constructs drew their items from different validated sources, which improved the validity of this research with regards to the measurement of the constructs.

Construct validity can be checked by *discriminant* and *convergent* validity (Chin, Gopal, & Salisbury, 1997). The results of convergent

Table 1
Sources of constructs, reliability and validity.

Codes	Scales	Factor loadings	CR	AVE	Cronbach's alpha
	Trust *Adapted from D. Gefen and D.W. Straub; HAN, BO and WINDSOR, JOHN*		0.874	0.536	0.828
T1	Promises made by SNSs are likely to be reliable	0.791			
T2	I do not doubt the honesty of SNSs	0.732			
T3	I expect that the advice given by SNSs is their best judgement	0.737			
T4	I believe SNSs have my information safety in minds	0.706			
T5	SNSs give me an impression that they keep my privacy information safe	0.709			
T6	SNSs (such as Facebook, MySpace) are trustworthy	0.763			
	Intention to Buy *Adapted from HAN, BO and WINDSOR, JOHN; Lu and Hsiao; D. Gefen and D.W. Straub*		0.801	0.510	0.711
IB1	I am likely to pay for fees to have speed dating on SNSs	0.722			
IB2	I am likely to pay for the membership if SNSs start charging fees	0.703			
IB3	I am very likely to buy books from SNSs	0.824			
IB4	I would use my credit card to purchase from SNSs	0.838			
	Recommendation and referrals *Adapted from HAN, BO and WINDSOR, JOHN*		0.879	0.656	0.813
RE1	I feel my friends' recommendations are generally frank	0.845			
RE2	I feel my friends' recommendations are generally reliable	0.839			
RE3	Overall, my friends' recommendations are trustworthy	0.851			
RE4	I trust my friends on SNSs and share my status, pictures with them	0.805			
	Forums and communities *Adapted from HAN, BO and WINDSOR, JOHN*		0.871	0.630	0.802
FC1	I feel my friends on forums and communities are generally frank	0.801			
FC2	I feel my friends on forums and communities reliable	0.700			
FC3	Overall, my friends on forums and communities are trustworthy	0.882			
FC4	I trust my friends on forums and communities and share my status, pictures with them	0.782			
	Rating and reviews *Adapted from HAN, BO and WINDSOR, JOHN*		0.904	0.702	0.858
RT1	I feel my friends rating and reviews are generally frank	0.823			
RT2	I feel my friends rating and reviews reliable	0.849			
RT3	Overall, my friends rating and reviews are trustworthy	0.885			
RT4	I trust my friends on rating and reviews and share my status, pictures with them	0.793			

Notes: CR, composite reliability; AVE, average variance extracted; T, trust; IB, intention to buy; RE, recommendations and referrals; RT, ratings and reviews; FC, forums and communities.

Table 2
Square of correlation between constructs.

	Forums and communities	Intention to buy	Rating and reviews	Recommendation and referrals	Trust
Forums and communities	**0.80**				
Intention to buy	0.388744	**0.72**			
Rating and reviews	0.51316	0.36317	**0.84**		
Recommendation and referrals	0.509202	0.327371	0.620878	**0.81**	
Trust	0.39646	0.47034	0.360911	0.384942	**0.74**

Notes: Numbers on the diagonal (in boldface) are the average variance extracted. Other numbers are the square of correlation.

test are shown in Table 1, where AVE in all constructs is more than 0.5 indicating that this research achieved these criteria.

Further assessment was made to test the validity of the research, discriminant validity, to gauge the extent to which a given construct of the research model is different from others (McLure Wasko & Faraj, 2005). As it is shown in Table 2, all AVEs are greater and demonstrate discriminant validity.

Another way to assess discriminant and convergent validity of the research is by examining the factor loadings of each indicator (McLure Wasko & Faraj, 2005). Table 3 shows the factor loadings for each construct and confirms that the observed indicators has enough convergent and discriminant validity. The author needs to mention that two items, intention to buy and trust, have been dropped due to low factor loading. These items are shown in Table 1. This helps to get better results from PLS. The overall results and scale have been checked to make sure the dropped items do not affect the model.

4.5. Structural model

The estimation results from SmartPLS software are shown in Fig. 2. According to the results, all the paths among constructs are positive and significant at the 0.05 level. The model validity is assessed by R square value and the structural paths (Chwelos, Benbasat, & Dexter, 2001). The results of the *R* square indicate that almost 30% of the variance in the intention to buy was accounted for by social commerce constructs and trust. It means intention to buy was, as hypothesized, affected by SCCs and trust. The R square for trust means that 28% of the variance in this construct was accounted for by SCCs. Hence, the result of R square shows a satisfactory level of explanation. In the following section, the relationships among these constructs are explained and interpreted. In addition, directed effects of social commerce constructs, trust and perceived usefulness are examined.

The research empirically tested social commerce constructs throughout the survery. To do this, the research performed bootstrapping to test the statistical significance of construct path coefficient by means of *t*-tests. The path coefficient and *t*-value has been shown in Fig. 2. The bootstrapping of 200 re-samples and 240 cases per sample shows social commerce constructs has a significant effect on intention to buy. Therefore, H1 is supported. The effect of SCCs on trust is also strongly supported. Hence, H2 is supported. Trust also positively affects intetion to buy, which supports H3.

According to the path coefficients, the direct effect of SCCs on trust (0.407) is stronger than that of intention to buy (0.233). This indicates that SCCs have more influence on trust than intention to buy. In fact, SCCs have influence on intention to buy directly and indirectly through trust. The path coefficient of trust in intention to buy (0.378) shows that direct effect of trust on intention to buy is stronger than SCCs. This indicates trust is more important than SCCs in intention to buy. Finally, the results of constructs path coefficient indicate that trust is the most important factor in determining user's intention to buy, followed by SCCs with a strong path coefficient.

5. Discussion

A social commerce adoption model has been developed in order to study consumer's behaviour in social commerce era. The results of this study show that consumers are increasingly using SNSs to share their knowledge, information, and experiences about a

Table 3
Cross loadings.

	Forums and communities	Intention to buy	Recommendation and referrals	Rating and reviews	Trust
FC1	**0.800471**	0.329931	0.688005	0.62159	0.286632
FC2	**0.699037**	0.352371	0.497193	0.508466	0.332643
FC3	**0.881783**	0.254574	0.71932	0.715373	0.317193
FC4	**0.781804**	0.31647	0.641389	0.71424	0.330931
IB1	0.153339	**0.721622**	0.148738	0.177938	0.258653
IB2	0.248987	**0.702764**	0.173106	0.178739	0.228793
IB3	0.306287	**0.823762**	0.253246	0.274998	0.40408
IB4	0.362728	**0.837106**	0.319263	0.359776	0.407054
RE1	0.633081	0.245338	**0.844159**	0.601222	0.291806
RE2	0.619011	0.304563	**0.838275**	0.639425	0.306974
RE3	0.684005	0.346784	**0.850499**	0.777026	0.37117
RE4	0.661377	0.135628	**0.804364**	0.602325	0.255844
RT1	0.587304	0.352256	0.654269	**0.822756**	0.268831
RT2	0.611567	0.311534	0.65492	**0.848529**	0.248898
RT3	0.755221	0.259022	0.752753	**0.884673**	0.320616
RT4	0.756814	0.301757	0.681416	**0.792566**	0.365455
T1	0.365039	0.49106	0.237294	0.21509	**0.790414**
T2	0.220782	0.331588	0.187766	0.20093	**0.731702**
T3	0.354482	0.327859	0.384519	0.413889	**0.736214**
T4	0.159287	0.333245	0.165205	0.149576	**0.705097**
T5	0.214142	0.222775	0.287018	0.202757	**0.708546**
T6	0.353499	0.309483	0.394662	0.350998	**0.762858**

Notes: Numbers on the diagonal (in boldface) are the factor loading of each item.

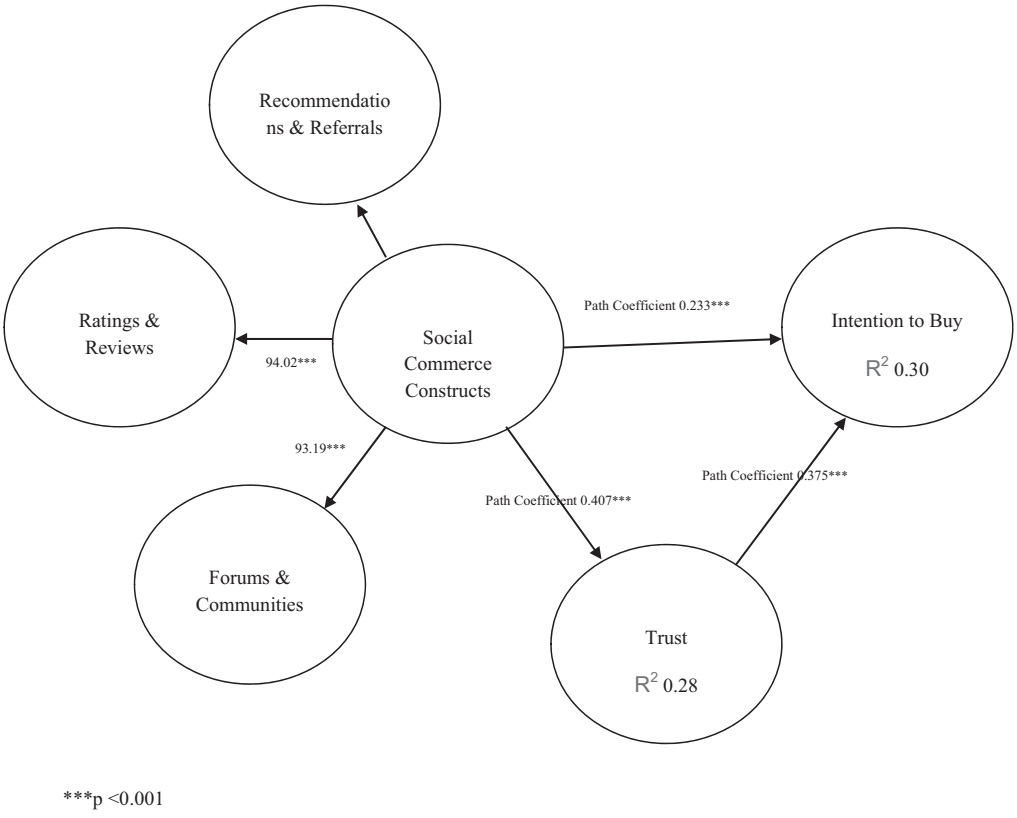


Fig. 2. Results of the PLS analysis, ***$p < 0.001$.

product or a service with their peers. They use social commerce constructs to have social interaction with their peers. Initially, the model emphasized the role of social relationships of individuals on the Internet and the paradigm change of transferring passive consumers of information to active content generators. Individuals are being rapidly attracted to SNSs, online communities and other social platforms and enjoy participation in creating content. The empowerment earned by consumers through social media makes them active users and encourages them to have social interactions with other consumers. These social relationships drive value for both businesses and consumers. Businesses are happy seeing consumers provide information for other consumers by their content generation. E-vendors also develop closer relationships with their customers, giving rise to better customer relationship management. Social commerce constructs are facilitated by these social interactions through the development of Web 2.0 technologies. In these platforms, consumers feel closer to each other and encourage each other to have more participation. This supportive climate helps to alleviate some big issues, such as trust, in the e-commerce market. Empirical tests significantly support the assertion that social commerce constructs will increase trust. Therefore, these platforms help to increase trust and intention to buy in consumers. In fact, SCCs on the Internet have developed e-commerce to social commerce by these advantages. Overall, this research indicates that social commerce constructs are more likely to attract individuals, increase trust and influence consumers' intention to buy.

5.1. Theoretical and practical contribution of this research

The present research highlights the role of social commerce constructs and how they shape social commerce and increase the level of trust and intention to buy. The practical contribution of this research is that the results emphasize the importance of social platforms provided by Web 2.0 technologies in social commerce era. As indicated in previous research (Yubo & Jinhong, 2005), it is important for firms to make a plan for reviews and to manage social platforms effectively as it has a significant impact on purchasing decisions of consumers.

The results give some practical instructions to e-vendors as to how social commerce constructs can be used as trust building mechanisms to influence consumer behaviour and intention to buy in SNSs. Social platforms such as forums and communities, recommendations and referrals, and ratings and reviews are the main element in social commerce to build that trust. Therefore, the firms may engage with their consumers in these platforms to develop trust.

In terms of theoretical implication, this research proposes a new model given the new concepts in social commerce. This research develops the literature of social commerce by introducing social commerce constructs through an empirical study. This research also discusses how these constructs can influence trust and intention to buy in a social commerce era.

5.2. Limitations and future research

The research is not without limitations. One of the research limitations is that the study used a five-point Likert-scale. The future research should test the scales using a seven-point Likert-scale to get better results. It may be valid to carry out similar research using LISREL, as most of the constructs have been tested in previous studies.

6. Conclusion

This research investigates the new stream in e-commerce; social commerce to offer better understanding of social commerce. In the

present study, the author borrowed some constructs from technology acceptance model to explain social commerce constructs and its influence on intention to buy and trust. Social commerce constructs, namely, forums and communities, ratings and reviews and recommendations and referrals are the main constructs of the social commerce adoption model. A research model with four constructs investigated the role of SCCs on intention to buy. It also validated the role and importance of trust. The findings of the research show that social commerce constructs are measured by forums and communities, ratings and reviews and recommendations and referrals and have been justified by?? (Is this correct?). The results of empirical testing, using PLS-SEM indicate the direct and significant effect of SCCs on intention to buy. The findings also show trust has a positive effect on intention to buy, consistent with many other TAM researches. Finally, the positive and significant effect of SCCs on trust is the other valuable result of the research. These findings give some highlights into the study of social commerce.

The main contribution of this research is that when empirically tested, social commerce constructs showed that social relationships and interactions of individuals in these platforms, which have emerged by Web 2.0 applications, influence consumer behaviour. The results also show that social commerce constructs give the opportunities for co-creation, participation, sharing information and collaboration between users, thus generating a value. These activities also have positive influence on intention to buy. The findings suggest to e-vendors that it is important to bring together and meet consumers by forming online communities. This enhances communication channels with customers and creates opportunities for marketing strategies that can benefit both vendors and consumers.

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